

trols most functions, including the air conditioning and seat ventilation. But we'd prefer physical or haptic buttons for these frequently used features to make on-the-go operation easier for the driver. The digital instrument cluster is equally comprehensive and adapts its theme based on the selected drive mode. The spacious centre console adds to the practicality by offering ample storage space.

Comfort is a priority. The seats are generously sized and supportive, while the panoramic moonroof with integrated light panels enhances the cabin's airy feel. Rear seat occupants are well-catered for too, with abundant legroom, a completely flat floor (thanks to the INGLO platform), Type-C charging ports for all passengers, and a bench that comfortably accommodates three.

Audio enthusiasts will appreciate the 16-speaker system that delivers a rich and immersive sound experience. The XEV 9e also features automatic parking, which can be activated even via the remote key when the driver is nearby. The system handles parallel and angled parking with ease and is calibrated for real-world Indian conditions, making it especially useful in urban environments. The SUV is offered with two battery pack options. The smaller 59kWh delivers 227 bhp, while the larger 79kWh unit boosts power to 282 bhp. Torque remains a healthy 380Nm across both variants. ARAI-certified ranges are 542 km and 656 km, respectively.

Mahindra XEV 9e
Motor: Single-motor, RWD
Power: 282 bhp/227 bhp
Torque: 380Nm
Transmission: Single-speed
Battery: 79kWh/59kWh
Range: 656 km/542 km
Top speed: 202 kmph
Price: ₹21.90 lakh (ex-showroom)
On sale now

Performance and ride quality are enhanced by semi-active dampers and a variable gear ratio steering system, designed to balance comfort with responsive handling. The front row feels large, and visibility all around is good. But the same cannot be said for the rear, as the sweeping roof line eats up the space. The XEV 9e offers good acceleration even in the lightest of modes. It also feels light to steer in traffic, and the small turning radius just adds to the effortless feel of driving. The ride quality at low speed is excellent, and so is the NVH packaging, which ensures a silent cocoon for the occupants. The good bit is that the SUV comes with a 'Boost' mode, which momentarily unleashes all the power from the motor and that makes overtaking effortless.

At higher speeds, though, the sheer weight and size of the vehicle are marginally felt. This is especially the case with the brakes, where one has to get used to the pedal feel—not as progressive as what we would have liked. The semi-active dampers do a great job of curtailing body roll around corners, but there is still some. On the upside, the XEV 9e is perhaps one of the best-handling SUVs in the segment. In all, it strikes a compelling balance between cutting-edge tech, family-centric practicality and electric performance. ■





The interior; (top) front boot space